

2.1 Or Surround Sound—What do you really need?

As you try to decide which speaker is best for you, a fundamental consideration is the primary intended use. Define your usage patterns first—are you an audiophile, does music occupy seventy five or more percent of your ‘speaker usage time’? Are you going to be using your speakers solely for movie watching with an occasional game?

The fact is, 2.1 speakers are ideally suitable for music, even more so than a 5.1 system. More does not necessarily mean better, and a good 2.1 set will outperform a similar priced 5.1 as far as those MP3s and audio CDs go. This is because all music today (5.1 DVD tracks being an exception) is encoded for two channel playback. A 2.1 speaker system can therefore pan and split the sound to its left and right channel easily and with minimum signal loss. 5.1 speakers have a more complex method of distributing sound to various channels and are not suitable for music. This doesn’t mean that they won’t play music well; but for the price of a decent 5.1 speaker you can get a really good 2.1 which will offer far more bang for your buck. So if its music you crave for, then it’s 2.1 you need!

A 5.1 setup excels at movies (especially DVD movies) and games. This is because the positioned speakers put you right in the middle of the action. Standards such as DTS and Dolby Prologic IIx make it a must to have a 5.1 system to accompany those DVD movies if you want to experience the movie the way the film makers intended. For gamers standards such as EAX Advanced HD ensure gripping game-play and realism. A 2.1 system just cannot give you the sheer immersive experience that a 6-channel setup can. For the movie buff/game freak the choice is clear—it’s the 5.1 way, or the highway.

The Umax PowerBeats UPB 980 and the Gigabyte GP-3A could not handle the test and produced almost no bass. The Altec Lansing MX-5021, Altec Lansing FX-6021 and the Creative I-Trigue 3400 were the best performers here and produced rich bass. This was expected due to their large woofer drivers and their well-ported subwoofer.

The extreme treble under this test was comfortably handled by the Altec Lansing MX-5021, the Altec Lansing CS21, and the Logitech Z-2300. The Umax PowerBeats UPB 980 could not keep up in this test as well.

5.1: SURROUNDED BY SOUND

While a decent 2.1-channel speaker set is enough for most folks, when it comes to games and a home theatre-like movie experience, a quality 5.1 channel solution would be a better choice. A 5.1 set can make a DVD come alive, and hardcore gamers should settle for nothing less.

The 5.1 segment is exciting because of the sheer variety of models available. The best (and sometimes unorthodox) looking speakers are usually found here. Falling prices mean that a 5.1 is well within most people’s reach. We received 15 such sets from 10 manufacturers. The prices, when compared, show that some 5.1 sets are actually cheaper than certain 2.1 sets. Less money, more sound!

A Look At Features

5.1 speaker sets are generally loaded with features. Their build

quality is also expected to be better in general. Most of the manufacturers didn’t disappoint.

Multiple inputs lacked in the case of most of the speakers. Only the Creative Inspire GD580 and the Logitech Z-5500D had more than one input option, with the inclusion of coaxial and optical inputs. None of the speakers had S/PDIF inputs.

Most of the 5.1s had some form of remote control—either a wired control pod or a wireless IR remote. Some had both; the Logitech Z-5500D comes to mind. It had a sleek control pod cum decoder. The Altec Lansing 151i and 251i and the Techcom SSD-2001 disappointed with no form of remote control whatsoever—unacceptable for a home theatre setup.

Most 5.1 speakers depend on the sound card to split sound into the six discrete channels. We gave extra points to speakers that had their own external decoders.

The Creative Inspire GD580, Logitech Z-5500D, Techcom SSD-

2001, Philips HTR5000 and the Artis S6600R all came with external decoder/splitter boxes. Among these, the Logitech Z-5500D was notable: its decoder was capable of a sampling rate of 96 KHz at 24-bit quality. The Creative Inspire GD580 and Logitech Z5500D were the only two sets that were fully THX-certified.

The process of setting up a 5.1 speaker system can sometimes be a pain, because of the sheer number of wires involved. Some users prefer plugs to the clamp system because it’s cleaner to set up. With the clamp system, one actually has to ensure that the clamp makes contact with the actual wires and not the insulation.

However the clamp system has one inherent advantage. As most people know, the sound quality depends to a great extent on the quality of wires, and if one feels the quality of the cables doesn’t match the speakers, the option of an upgrade to better-quality, higher grade wires is always there.

With plug connectors, an upgrade becomes a problem. Moreover, if any of the speaker cables get damaged with the plug-type connectors, replacements will always be a problem.

Cable quality was decent throughout the 5.1 range; nothing spectacular, but no gripes either. Looks like manufacturers have finally understood that bad-quality cables tremendously hamper performance.

We faced a peculiar problem while setting the Frontech JIL-1875 speakers: the colour coding for the centre speaker and subwoofer were found to be reversed. This was quite irritating, because the subwoofer kept playing bass for the centre channel until we remedied this by simply swapping the wires. Colour coding is supposed to make setting up easy? Quite the opposite here!

We were blown away by the enormous size of the Logitech Z-5500D’s subwoofer, and we thought its carton was huge! The subwoofer with its massive 10-inch driver (the largest subwoofer we’ve received to date) was heavy too, and it took two people to lift it out of its box! Its control pod cum decoder with its cool blue backlit LCD panel was also a plus.

The Philips HTR5000 looked rather sexy with its narrow subwoofer and satellites with horn-like micro drivers. The decoder box



Altec Lansing FX-6021